



Temperate forest

Away from the tropics, climates are cooler with distinct winters and summers. Temperate regions with short, mild winters and regular rainfall are naturally covered by woodland, mostly made up of deciduous trees, which lose their leaves in winter and grow new ones in spring. This creates a seasonal habitat with most of the plant and animal activity taking place during the warmer months of the year.



FOREST ZONES

Temperate forests grow in places with mild oceanic climates. The warmest, wettest regions, such as New Zealand and Oregon, have temperate rainforests of evergreen trees. But cooler areas, such as northern Europe and New England, have deciduous woodland that stops growing in winter.

DECIDUOUS TREES

Leaves soak up sunlight to make food. The broad evergreen leaves of tropical trees are very good at this, but cannot survive frost. The tougher leaves of trees such as holly survive, but are less efficient. By contrast, deciduous trees, like this one, have broad, thin leaves that make all the food the tree needs in just a few months, and are then discarded and replaced.



SPRING FLOWERS

Since deciduous trees have no leaves in winter, the forest floor is flooded with light in early spring. Plants such as these bluebells grow fast and burst into bloom, soaking up the sun to make their seeds before the new tree foliage creates too much shade. These plants vanish in winter, but their bulbs stay alive below ground, insulated from the cold by a blanket of fallen leaves.

◀ FLOWER SHOW

Bluebells carpet an English woodland in May, as new leaves appear on the beech trees overhead.